



**Expedia - CarTrawler**

MN-90022

# **Phase 1 Determination**

**Acquisition may be put into effect**

13 August 2026

# 1. Determination and statement of reasons

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| <b>Notified acquisition</b>                         | Expedia Group, Inc. ( <b>Expedia</b> ) proposes to acquire the entire issued share capital of Ballast Group Holdings Ltd (trading as <b>CarTrawler</b> ) (the <b>Acquisition</b> ).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| <b>Determination</b>                                | The Australian Competition and Consumer Commission has determined under section 51ABZE(1) of the <i>Competition and Consumer Act 2010</i> (Cth) that the Acquisition may be put into effect.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>Parties to the Acquisition</b>                   | <p>Expedia operates online travel agency brands, including Expedia.com, Hotels.com, and Vrbo, and is the majority owner of Trivago, which is principally a hotel meta-search site. Expedia is primarily active in the supply of online booking intermediation services on a standalone and package basis for hotel rooms, flights, car rental, activities and experiences, cruises and alternative accommodations to consumers.</p> <p>In addition to its consumer-facing (<b>B2C</b>) operations, Expedia also provides business-to business (<b>B2B</b>) intermediation distribution solutions, which enable a wide range of travel and non-travel partners (including airlines, offline travel agents, online retailers, corporate travel management, financial institutions, and other distributors of travel booking services) to utilise Expedia's technology to access and distribute travel products, including car rental services.</p> <p>CarTrawler is a global provider of distribution solutions for car rental, ground transportation and travel-related insurance. CarTrawler primarily offers B2B solutions that enable third-party travel partners, such as airlines, online travel agencies, tour operators and other travel distributors, to offer car rental services through their own B2C customer interfaces. CarTrawler's "Connect" platform is a proprietary B2B technology platform that supports end to-end booking, availability and pricing aggregation, payments, and ancillary travel insurance products. The platform is integrated into partners' existing booking flows via APIs, allowing CarTrawler's business customers (e.g. airlines, online travel agencies, etc.) to offer car rental products to end consumers.</p> <p>CarTrawler also operates two B2C brands, Holiday Autos and Angus Car Hire, which both supply online car rental comparison and reservation services.</p> |
| <b>Overlap and relationship between the Parties</b> | <p>Expedia and CarTrawler (together, the <b>Parties</b>) overlap in the supply of car rental booking services via online intermediated channels, including in the supply of business-to-business (<b>B2B</b>) and business-to-consumer (<b>B2C</b>) car rental intermediation distribution solutions.</p> <p>There is also a non-horizontal relationship between the Parties' products through CarTrawler's B2B "Connect" platform being used as an input into online travel agency services and in conjunction with a range of other B2B intermediation distribution solutions.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Reasons for determination</b>                    | When making a determination in Phase 1, the Australian Competition and Consumer Commission ( <b>ACCC</b> ) undertakes a competition assessment and considers whether it is appropriate for an acquisition to be approved or subject to further assessment in                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |

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|                                | <p>Phase 2 in accordance with section 51ABZJ of the <i>Competition and Consumer Act 2010</i> (Cth) (the <b>Act</b>). In doing so, the ACCC must have regard to the object of the Act and all relevant matters, including the interests of consumers.</p> <p>For more information about the ACCC's approach to considering notified acquisitions, see the ACCC's <a href="#">merger assessment guidelines</a> and <a href="#">interim merger process guidelines</a>.</p> <p>In conducting its competition assessment, the ACCC has considered the information and documents that were submitted with the notification form and information from third parties.</p> <p>The ACCC has determined that the Acquisition may be put into effect as it considers that the Acquisition is unlikely to have the effect of substantially lessening competition in any market. In reaching its decision, and based on the material before it, the ACCC makes the following findings.</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• There is limited overlap between the Parties in the supply of both B2B and B2C car rental intermediation distribution solutions and the merged entity would likely continue to face competition from alternative suppliers of car rental intermediation distribution solutions in Australia.</li> <li>• The merged entity would be unlikely to have the ability and incentive to foreclose rival online travel agencies' access to B2B car rental intermediation distribution solutions, due to the availability of alternative suppliers to CarTrawler.</li> <li>• The merged entity would also be unlikely to have the ability and incentive to foreclose rival B2B car rental intermediation distribution solution providers' access to customers. While Expedia is a leading online travel agency, there are likely sufficient alternative potential partners for rival B2B car rental intermediation distribution solution providers including alternative online travel agencies, other travel agents and airlines.</li> </ul> |
| <b>Applications for review</b> | <p>A notifying party, or other person who has been allowed to do so by the Australian Competition Tribunal, may apply for review if they are dissatisfied with the determination. Pursuant to section 100C of the Act, applications for review of the determination are to be made to the Australian Competition Tribunal before the end of 14 calendar days after this statement of reasons was included on the ACCC's Acquisitions Register. To confirm whether there has been any application for review, please contact the Australian Competition Tribunal.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |

**Determination made by Commissioner Williams pursuant to a delegation under section 25(1) of the Act**